

SHIRDI TEMPLE

UNSAFE IN THE ABODE OF SAI

By Dhaval S. Kulkarni in Shirdi

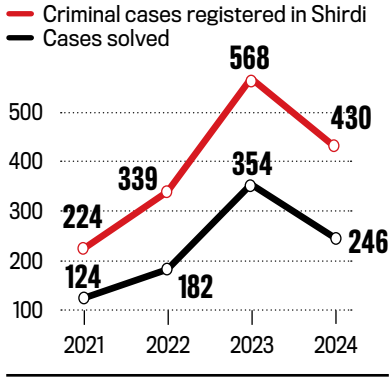
In the wee hours of the morning on February 3, two employees of the Saibaba temple trust in Shirdi, Subhash Ghode and Nitin Shejul, were attacked and killed at different locations while they were heading to work. Another employee, Krishna Deharkar, was seriously injured in one of the attacks—apparently random crimes that occurred in the span of half-an-hour. Two assailants, Kiran Sadaphule and Shakya Mali were arrested later and, if local police are to be believed, robbery was the only motive. The horrific incidents, though, led to anger and panic among the local populace of one of India's most revered pilgrimage destinations.

Jolted into action, Shirdi residents called a 'gram sabha' meeting where it was decided that the Shirdi Municipal Council would conduct an unprecedented "local census" in the town to "identify outsiders" engaged in illegitimate work and those with criminal antecedents. The gram sabha also decided that all establishments will be shut between 11.00 pm and 5.30 am, and that residents will stay indoors unless they have a valid reason.

It's fast becoming a pushback with a strong classist tenor. Locals claim a big reason for the increase in the crime rate is the "riff-raff" the town is attracting due to the free meals provided by the Shri Saibaba Sansthan Trust in Shirdi, which administers the temple. This, they allege, has led to a proliferation of "beggars, criminals and touts" flocking to Shirdi, many of whom work as commission agents for the hotels and other establishments that have mushroomed in the town. Locally known as 'polishwalas', they are also being blamed for the rise in cheating cases filed by devotees. The two accused in the February 3 murders also worked as polishwalas.

The temple town of Shirdi, located around 250 km from Mumbai, gets devotees from across the world who come and offer their prayers at the temple of the saint, Shirdi Saibaba. And like in the case of many famous temples, the free '*annaprasadam*' meals is a must-have for devotees. The prasadalaya here is enormous, capable of serving 3,500 people in one go. Temple authorities claim that, on average, around 50,000 people eat here daily, with the number shooting up to around 85,000 on weekends and festivals. The meals are funded by donations from devotees. Shirdi's locals want the free meal scheme to

CRIME PATROL





"We are installing CCTV cameras to cover more areas in Shirdi. A local crime branch division has also been set up"

RAKESH OLA
Ahilyanagar SP